

The Autocracy Bandwagon: Electoral Institutions and Elite Selection in Authoritarian Regimes*

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Abstract

This paper examines how democratic politicians survive authoritarian reversals by securing regime trust. While research shows how authoritarian institutions help dictators share power, we argue that these institutions also allow politicians to credibly abandon oppositional ambitions by publicly joining the ruling party—a strategy especially relevant for those at greatest risk of repression. Using individual-level data from Brazil’s last legislative elections before the 1964 right-wing coup, and combining a difference-in-differences design with a regression discontinuity approach, we show that left-wing incumbents were the regime’s most vulnerable targets—as indicated by intensified post-coup surveillance—and were more likely than unelected leftists to join the ruling party but not more likely to join the opposition or exit politics. No comparable pattern appears among non-left politicians, who faced lower regime risk. These findings illuminate the microfoundations of strategic adaptation under autocracy, revealing how electoral institutions facilitate elite realignment and strengthen authoritarian consolidation.

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During democratic breakdowns, democratic politicians occupy a paradoxical position: they are democracy’s strongest potential defenders yet also its most vulnerable political actors. Their ability to mobilize voters, forge alliances with social movements, and attract international attention makes them central to efforts to resist authoritarian encroachment (Mainwaring and Pérez-Liñán, 2013; Gamboa, 2017; Collier, 1999; Levitsky and Way, 2006; Haggard and Kaufman, 2016; Acemoglu and Robinson, 2005). But these same capacities heighten their visibility and render them prime targets for repression, purges, or co-optation as autocrats seek to consolidate power (Lust-Okar, 2005; Goldring and Matthews, 2023; Hassan, Mattingly and Nugent, 2022). How do democratic politicians navigate these transitions to preserve their political survival?

For many, survival under autocracy depends on accommodation rather than resistance. Authoritarian governments often reward those they co-opt, offering access to office, resources, and protection in exchange for loyalty. Legacy politicians—those who ran for office before democracy’s collapse—therefore face a defining choice: to resist the new regime, withdraw from public life, or continue their careers within the emerging authoritarian order. While ideological allies of the dictator may naturally embrace collaboration, even politicians once aligned with organized civil society, such as labor unions, or from parties without ideological affinity to the dictator, may find accommodation attractive as a means to preserve influence and avoid persecution.

Demonstrating loyalty to an autocrat, however, is rarely straightforward. The very traits that make legacy politicians valuable for the dictator — political experience, resources, and deep social networks — also make them threatening to the regime. Their challenge is not merely to abandon opposition but to do so credibly: to signal to the dictator that they are reliable allies rather than potential rivals. How can legacy politicians signal commitment to a ruler who views them as possible threats?

We argue that authoritarian electoral institutions provide a mechanism through which threatened politicians can credibly signal loyalty to the new regime and secure their political survival. Existing research shows that institutions such as parties and legislatures help dictators make power-sharing commitments credible (Geddes et al.,

1999; Gandhi and Przeworski, 2007; Brancati, 2014; Svolik, 2008).¹ We extend this logic to the elites on the other side of the bargain. Authoritarian institutions also help legacy politicians solve a credibility problem of their own by demonstrating to the dictator that they have renounced oppositional ambitions. Formally joining the regime’s party is a clear and costly gesture of allegiance, one that is especially appealing to politicians who pose the greatest threat to the ruler because of their electoral mandates, visibility, or ideological distance.

This argument generates a broader set of expectations about how threatened elites adapt under authoritarianism. In this paper, we focus on two that lend themselves to systematic empirical evaluation. First, opposition politicians with greater political clout should attract closer surveillance once autocrats consolidate power, as their electoral mandates and visibility make them especially threatening to the regime (Esberg, 2021). Second, these same politicians should have the strongest incentives to issue credible—and costly—signals of loyalty by affiliating with the ruling party rather than withdrawing from politics or joining the regime-sanctioned opposition. Together, these implications reveal how the very politicians who once embodied democratic competition can become instrumental in consolidating authoritarian rule.

We evaluate these expectations in the context of Brazil’s 1964 military coup, which transformed Brazilian democracy into a durable right-wing authoritarian regime. Drawing on original data linking every candidate from Brazil’s 1962 legislative elections—the last democratic contest before the coup—to their post-coup trajectories, we analyze how pre-coup elites were monitored and incorporated under military rule. Using newly declassified intelligence archives, we first document the surveillance of politicians across ideological lines before and after the establishment of the dictatorship. A difference-in-differences design, based on the number of intelligence files referencing each politician, reveals that incumbents—particularly those from the left—were subjected to markedly greater scrutiny once the regime consolidated power, underscoring their heightened exposure to risk under autocracy.

We then analyze how pre-coup politicians adapted once the regime institution-

¹Some scholars, however, contend that dictators often evade consequences for reneging on such commitments (Boix and Svolik, 2013; Meng, Paine and Powell, 2022).

alized a two-party system in 1966, compelling politicians to choose between exiting politics, affiliating with the sanctioned opposition—the Movimento Democrático Brasileiro (MDB)—or joining the regime’s Aliança Renovadora Nacional (ARENA), the clearest public signal of loyalty to the dictatorship. Consistent with our argument, descriptive evidence indicates that incumbency—the most visible form of political prominence—had little effect on the choices of non-left-wing politicians. Among left-wing politicians, however, incumbents were just as likely to join the ruling party as to affiliate with the opposition and substantially more likely to do so than their unelected counterparts. To evaluate this pattern more rigorously, we employ a regression-discontinuity design exploiting close electoral races in the 1962 democratic contest. The results show that incumbency did not significantly affect whether left-wing politicians exited politics but sharply increased their likelihood of joining the ruling party and reduced their likelihood of affiliating with the opposition. By contrast, incumbency had no discernible effect among non-left-wing politicians. Together, these findings suggest that the alignment of former opposition elites with the dictatorship reflected strategic adaptation under asymmetric risk.

The paper contributes to research on authoritarian institutions and elite behavior in three ways. First, it extends theories of authoritarian power-sharing by demonstrating that institutions serve a dual function: they allow dictators to make credible commitments and enable threatened elites to credibly commit to the dictator. Second, it provides micro-level evidence that authoritarian elections function as mechanisms of political control, structuring the incentives of ambitious politicians and giving them institutional channels to signal loyalty rather than resist. Third, it identifies an overlooked source of regime consolidation: the self-selection of prominent democratic politicians into the ruling coalition, showing how individual survival strategies can reinforce the durability of authoritarian rule. More broadly, the study highlights how electoral institutions that appear to expand political competition can instead weaken it—enabling autocrats to secure loyalty from the very actors best positioned to challenge them.

Legacy Politicians and Political Survival in Authoritarian Transitions

Most theories of politician behavior in democracies rest on the assumption that elected officials seek above all to retain office. Authoritarian reversals confront them with a related but distinct dilemma: whether—and how—to sustain their political careers within the new authoritarian order. They must weigh the expected benefits of remaining in office—preserving the networks, resources, and reputational capital that sustain their influence (Dal Bó, Dal Bó and Snyder, 2009; Ferraz, Finan and Martinez-Bravo, 2020)—against the potential costs of doing so under autocratic rule. Under authoritarian rule, parties and legislatures create new opportunities for political survival while serving as instruments of control (Magaloni, 2006). Confronted with these constraints, politicians can respond in one of three ways: by exiting electoral politics, opposing the regime, or collaborating with it.

Strategic responses to authoritarian takeover When the pursuit of office comes into conflict with personal security, political ambition yields to survival. Under such circumstances, exit becomes a strategic response to coercion and uncertainty. Withdrawing from politics allows elites to minimize immediate exposure to repression while safeguarding their families and assets. By removing themselves from contention, exiting politicians reduce the regime’s immediate threats, but they also forfeit the networks and influence that once anchored their power.

Opposing the regime represents the most principled—but also the most perilous—response to authoritarian takeover. For elites whose political standing depends on opposition networks, continued resistance preserves ideological coherence, sustains visibility among supporters (Desposato, 2001), and positions them for potential advantage should democracy return (Zucco and Power, 2025). These benefits, however, are largely speculative, whereas the risks are immediate. Dictators, aware of opposition elites’ mobilizational capacity, view them with deep suspicion. Limited opposition can lend an aura of legitimacy to authoritarian rule (Gandhi, 2008; Gandhi and Lust-Okar, 2009), yet autocrats recognize that today’s tolerated rivals

can become tomorrow’s challengers (Magaloni, 2006; Acemoglu and Robinson, 2005). Politicians with strong ties to organized constituencies—such as labor unions, religious organizations, or ethnic movements—are especially threatening, since they can channel social discontent into collective action (Meng, Paine and Powell, 2022). Anticipating this danger, dictators frequently resort to repression, purges, or imprisonment (Shen-Bayh, 2018), rendering opposition not only costly but often fatal. Only a narrow subset of elites are willing to bear such risks (Mainwaring and Pérez-Liñán, 2013).

For many elites, the most viable path to survival is collaboration. Aligning with the regime offers immediate security, access to political resources Lust-Okar (2006); Blaydes (2010), and the prospect of continued relevance under authoritarian rule (Lust-Okar, 2004; Gandhi and Przeworski, 2006). It also serves the dictator’s interests by broadening the ruling coalition and lending an appearance of political continuity (Magaloni, 2006). Yet collaboration is not cost-free. Politicians who join the regime risk alienating their previous constituencies and severing ties with social or ideological networks that once sustained them.

More fundamentally, collaboration raises a problem of credibility. Dictators have little reason to trust politicians who were not part of the coup coalition, who are ideologically distant, or who command independent followings beyond regime control. For such actors, mere declarations of loyalty carry little weight. Their political survival depends on demonstrating allegiance in ways that are public, costly, and therefore credible to the regime. In this sense, the problem facing many would-be collaborators is not whether to cooperate, but how to make their cooperation believable.

The logic of credible signaling under authoritarian rule We argue that authoritarian electoral institutions help resolve this credibility problem by transforming elections and parties into mechanisms of elite signaling. Prior research emphasizes that such institutions serve the dictator’s interests—allowing autocrats to identify, monitor, and incorporate potential rivals while credibly committing to share power (Geddes et al., 1999; Gandhi and Przeworski, 2007; Brancati, 2014; Meng, 2020;

Svolik, 2008).² We extend this logic to the other side of the bargain. These same institutions also provide legacy politicians with a formalized platform on which to demonstrate their loyalty. Formally joining the ruling party constitutes the clearest—and costliest—signal of allegiance: it publicly affirms support for the dictatorship, severs ties with opposition networks, and raises the reputational and strategic costs of future defection. In this way, electoral institutions perform a dual function—enabling dictators to co-opt potential opponents while allowing threatened elites to credibly pledge fidelity to the regime.

The extent to which politicians confront the credibility problem and can benefit from publicly signaling loyalty depends on both the rewards of remaining in power and the degree of threat they face from the regime. Those perceived as most dangerous to the dictator—because of their visibility, popular support, or ideological distance—face the highest risk of repression and thus the strongest incentives to demonstrate allegiance if they wish to remain in politics. For politicians whose ideological ties are too deep or too publicly visible to plausibly abandon, joining the ruling party signals nothing. The regime would discount this effort, and the reputational cost with their own constituency would be immediate. Where defection lacks plausibility, should not operate.³

Incumbents are especially exposed. Their recent electoral victories attest to their mobilizational capacity, public visibility, and access to organizational networks that could challenge the regime (Esberg, 2021). Precisely for these reasons, they are more likely to attract the dictator’s scrutiny and to seek protection through visible displays of loyalty. To reduce the risk of exclusion or persecution and to preserve their careers, incumbents have powerful incentives to align with the ruling party and distance themselves from the opposition. Hence, among politicians from the opposing ideological camp and outside the initial coup coalition, those who are most prominent should be the most likely to join the regime as a strategy of political survival. We focus on incumbency as our measure of prominence. It is visible to the regime and

²See Hartnett and Saleh (2025) for an example of how institutions help power-sharing in colonial arrangements.

³For an extreme example, any attempt by Chilean communists to switch to Pinochet’s side would not be credible.

to the public, and as we discuss below, it lends itself to causal identification.

By contrast, politicians who are less visible or ideologically closer to the regime face weaker incentives to issue costly signals of loyalty. Their lower perceived threat makes repression unlikely, and their political survival does not depend on conspicuous demonstrations of allegiance. For these elites, joining the ruling party can still offer advantages, such as access to patronage or influence. However, it is not essential for avoiding persecution. Aligning with the sanctioned opposition, or even temporarily withdrawing from politics, entails comparatively little risk. Consequently, for politicians who are ideologically proximate to the regime or lack strong popular followings, incumbency should have minimal effect on their decision to collaborate with the dictatorship.

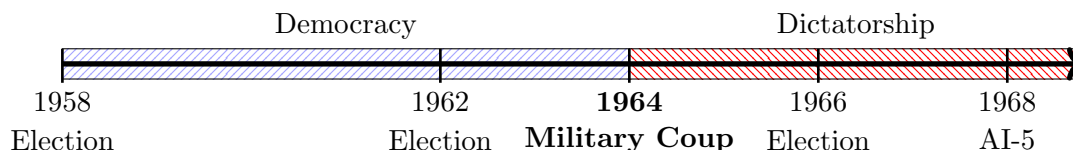
In sum, legacy politicians navigating authoritarian transitions make strategic choices shaped by how threatening they appear to the new regime. Those at highest risk—particularly elected officials with ideological or social ties outside the ruling coalition—are most likely to seek safety and continuity by aligning with the ruling party. Less prominent or ideologically proximate elites, by contrast, can afford to remain in the opposition or exit politics without jeopardizing their security. The dynamics of incumbency, visibility, and ideological distance thus determine who resists and who adapts when democracy collapses.

Background

We examine our argument in the context of Brazil’s 1964 military dictatorship, which began with the ouster of President João Goulart of the Brazilian Labor Party (PTB) and lasted until 1985. Goulart’s presidency was marked by a chaotic administration with ambitious redistributive proposals—land reform, expanded workers’ rights (Figueiredo, 1993), and increased state intervention in the economy—that alarmed conservative sectors of society and the armed forces, who feared a leftist radicalization and potential class revolt (Fontes and Corrêa, 2018). The PTB, a populist party rooted in the labor movement and founded by Getúlio Vargas, had become Brazil’s strongest left-wing organization but struggled to contain labor mil-

itancy. This loss of control over its mass base, which Collier and Collier (2002) identify as a key trigger of the 1964 crisis, convinced the military and its civilian allies that Brazil’s democratic order was no longer sustainable.

Figure 1: Timing of Brazil’s Elections and Regime Transition, 1958-1968



The figure indicates the timing of key political events. The paper analyzes the cohort of candidates who ran for office in 1962 and tracks their decision to exit politics or to contest the 1966 elections under the regime’s ARENA or the opposition’s MDB.

The coup reflected a broad right-wing coalition of military officers, industrial and financial elites, landowners, major media groups, and segments of the Catholic Church—actors united by Cold War fears of a Communist advance. On March 31, 1964, the armed forces deposed Goulart amid economic stagnation, high inflation, and widespread social unrest. Although some military leaders, including the first president, Castello Branco, initially envisioned a short-lived transition followed by a return to civilian rule (Gaspari, 2014), the dictatorship persisted for nearly two decades—an outlier case when compared to other military dictatorships (Amorim Neto and Acácio, 2019).

Once in power, the military swiftly consolidated control through a series of executive decrees known as *Atos Institucionais* (Institutional Acts). These measures curtailed civil liberties, suspended political rights, and signaled to politicians that opposition carried severe risks. The first decree, AI-1, issued one week after the coup, removed 102 elected officials from office—among them forty-two of 409 federal deputies—making clear that political survival required accommodation.

Initially, the regime allowed pre-coup parties to contest elections. But after opposition candidates captured several key governorships, the military reversed course. In 1965, AI-2 dissolved all existing parties and imposed a two-party system: the

pro-regime Aliança Renovadora Nacional (ARENA) and the officially sanctioned opposition, the Movimento Democrático Brasileiro (MDB) (Kinzo, 1988; Fleischer, 1980; Lamounier and Meneguello, 1986).⁴ This arrangement restricted political competition but preserved the institutional façade of democracy.⁵

Economically, the regime pursued orthodox stabilization policies that severely undermined labor interests. The Governmental Action in the Economy Program (PAEG) curbed inflation and reestablished ties with foreign creditors but sharply reduced real wages (Bastian, 2013). These measures, combined with the earlier purge of leftist politicians and union leaders, neutralized the labor movement as a political force. By the late 1960s, the dictatorship had simultaneously repressed organized opposition and integrated much of the remaining political elite into a tightly controlled but enduring authoritarian order (Kaufman, Nelson et al., 2004; Collier and Collier, 2002).

During its two decades in power, the military reshaped Brazil’s political landscape while preserving much of the preexisting civilian elite. Rather than dismantling representative institutions, the regime used them to consolidate control. Parties, legislatures, and elections became instruments of co-optation and patronage, channeling political ambition into a regime-compatible framework (Geddes et al., 2018, 183). This arrangement forged a durable power-sharing pact through which the dictatorship sought to legitimize itself and maintain stability.⁶

Participation in the new authoritarian order was not equally attainable or credible for all politicians. Those associated with conservative or centrist parties could transition smoothly into the regime’s patronage networks, but collaboration posed a far greater challenge for politicians linked to the pre-coup left. In the context of

⁴The AI-2 also authorized the executive to close Congress, a power the regime exercised three times: for one month in 1966, for nearly a year in 1968–69, and for two weeks in 1977.

⁵The dictatorship even expanded turnout by extending compulsory voting to women and stiffening penalties for abstention (Nicolau, 2012). Yet, illiterate adults—then a substantial portion of the electorate—remained disenfranchised.

⁶Control over state resources has long been central to political mobilization in Brazil (Leal, 2012). As Hagopian (2007) shows, while the military initially viewed clientelistic politicians as a source of backwardness, it later relied on patronage to integrate them into the regime, extending control and legitimacy across the federation.

fears of a working-class uprising (Fontes and Corrêa, 2018), members of the Brazilian Labor Party (PTB)—the dominant force on the left—faced acute credibility problems if they sought to align with the dictatorship. Founded by Getúlio Vargas and deeply rooted in the labor movement, the PTB had served as the political home of President João Goulart, many of his ministers, and former Communist cadres after the dissolution of their party in 1948 (D’Araujo, 1996). These ties to organized labor, redistributive agendas, and the ousted president himself made PTB politicians both immediate targets of repression and objects of deep suspicion among the military. While the labor movement maintained only tenuous institutional links to political parties, any post-coup alliance between labor activists and PTB leaders would have posed a direct threat to regime stability (Collier and Collier, 2002). Incorporating PTB figures thus offered the military both an opportunity and a risk: bringing them into the ruling coalition could help neutralize labor unrest, but their organizational strength and social reach also made them potentially dangerous allies.

This context crystallized the central dilemma identified in our theory. To survive politically, left-leaning incumbents had to signal credible loyalty to a regime that viewed them as existential threats. Their challenge was not merely to declare allegiance but to demonstrate it in observable and costly ways. The institutional framework created after 1964—particularly the two-party system introduced in 1965—offered precisely that stage. Joining the regime’s Aliança Renovadora Nacional (ARENA) provided the clearest and most public signal of acquiescence, while affiliating with the Movimento Democrático Brasileiro (MDB) marked continued distance from the dictatorship. In this sense, Brazil’s authoritarian institutions did more than structure competition: they institutionalized the very process of political survival that our argument describes.

Data

We analyze the trajectories of legacy politicians in Brazil by tracing candidates from the 1962 state and federal legislative elections. To do this, we collected historical electoral data from the electoral authority (TSE), which provides data on all

congressional elections starting in 1933.⁷ We used candidate names to track individual political behavior over time. We created unique identifiers for all candidates on file until the 1980s using fuzzy name matching, allowing for a maximum Jaro-Winkler distance threshold of 0.1.

Our historical dataset requires that we take some discretion when operationalizing variables. One such decision concerns how we classify candidates' ideology, since the ideological identification of parties is not clearly defined.⁸ We address this by using the coalition classifications in Coppedge (1997), who recruited local experts to classify the ideology of Brazilian parties over time.

Surveillance We collected data on regime surveillance. We accessed the full archive of the dictatorship's intelligence service, available through the Brazilian National Archives (*Arquivo Nacional*), and identified all mentions to our cohort of 1962 candidates. With this information, we constructed a variable recording the number of intelligence files mentioning each candidate. Because the files include the year of the report, we were able to distinguish between files produced during the dictatorship and those reports published after 1966. We are interested in understanding the differences in the regime's surveillance effort across groups of legacy politicians, as these measure how the regime perceived them as a threat and, consequently, potential targets for persecution. Ultimately, we want to understand how the likelihood of being persecuted is linked to the politicians' choice of whether to join the regime or not. Thus, we restrict the analysis to 1966 since that is the year in which politicians chose their party affiliation.

Political selection Our main dependent variables measure the political aftermath of legacy politicians. We consider three different outcomes. Candidates that do not participate in the 1966 Congressional elections are classified as having exited politics.⁹

⁷Data on local elections have been archived on state electoral authorities and are not readily available. For this reason, we do not extend our analysis to lower-level politicians.

⁸One additional complication is that in 1962, politicians did not run on party lists but in ad hoc state-level coalitions. Fortunately, Coppedge (1997) classifies the ideology of these coalitions.

⁹Candidates might have returned to local politics, but there are no available records of local politics at the national level.

Among those who ran for office in 1966, they may have done so by joining the Arena or MDB.

Legacy Politicians and Surveillance

Dictators have strong reasons to worry about whether legacy politicians will oppose them. To better assess the threat presented by political elites, dictators often employ elaborate surveillance infrastructure to monitor them. However, we argue that the threat levels for different groups of politicians will be different, which would translate into greater effort to monitor some. Particularly, we hypothesize that incumbents who have not been part of the coup coalition and who, in the past, have established linkages with popular sectors, would be more closely monitored. In Brazil, the dictatorship established precisely such an apparatus starting from pre-existing agencies.¹⁰ We analyze now-declassified surveillance files from the period preceding the creation of the two-party system—when politicians lacked institutional channels to credibly signal loyalty—to assess whether the Brazilian dictatorship devoted particular attention to left-wing politicians.

We begin by showing that the number of politicians under the scope of government intelligence agencies skyrocketed in 1964, the year of the military coup. Figure 2 shows that such was the case for all politicians. However, when analyzing politicians from the left separately from others, we can see that the increase in attention was larger for them.

We then proceed to a more careful analysis of this dynamic. We employ a

¹⁰The National Service of Information (Serviço Nacional de Informação - SNI in Portuguese), started operating shortly after the 1964 coup. Created to gather information on potential threats against the regime, it became the backbone of its repressive forces after absorbing other pre-existing intelligence agencies. Two military presidents (Emílio Médici and João Figueiredo) served as SNI bosses, an intelligence agency structured with several regional offices, spies, and collaborators. The mastermind behind its creation, General Golbery Couto e Silva, would later call the service a “monster” due to the dimension the agency took in terms of spying on Brazilians. While the primary goal was to spy on “subversives”, it would eventually be used indiscriminately to track all political adversaries of SNI local bosses and their allies. Researchers have estimated that the service issued dossiers for more than three hundred thousand individuals and organizations.¹¹ We provide additional information on the type of content of these files in Appendix Section B.

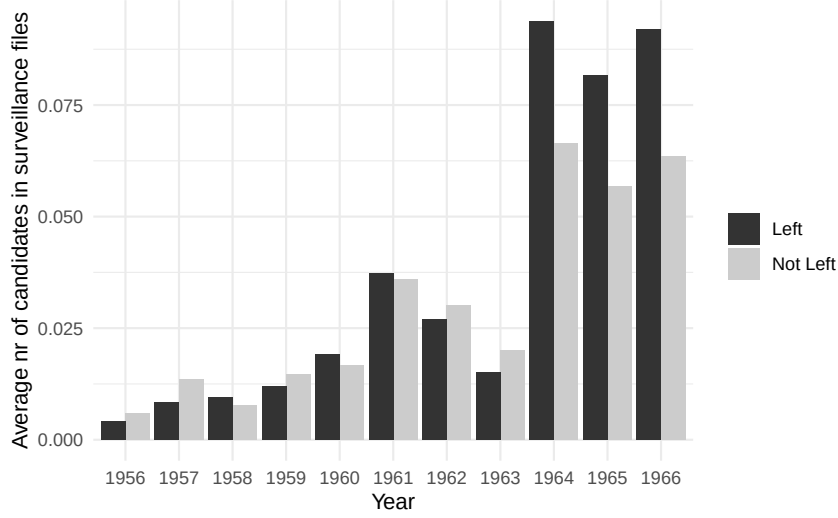


Figure 2: Surveillance of politicians over time.

differences-in-differences analysis to carefully measure how the surveillance apparatus targeted left-wing incumbents. First, we estimate an event-study model described in Equation 1.

$$Y_{it} = \beta_0 + \sum_{j \in J, j \neq -1} \gamma_j (D_{j,it} \times \text{Elected}_{it}) + \beta X_{it} + \alpha_i + \delta_t + \epsilon_{it} \quad (1)$$

where Y_{it} represent the surveillance for legacy politician i on year $t \in \{1958, \dots, 1966\}$. The coefficient γ_j estimates the interaction of $D_{j,it}$, an indicator for each period of analysis, and Elected_{it} , which indicates if politician i was elected in 1962. We are mostly interested in the years starting in 1964, the year of the coup. The coefficients α_i and δ_i indicate politician and year fixed-effects, respectively, and X_{it} a vector of controls.

Figures 3 and 4 report the event-study results. The first plots the share of politicians appearing in surveillance files by year, while the second counts the frequency of their appearances across documents. Whereas Figure 2 shows a surge in intelligence activity, the event-study reveals that this increase was uneven. Incumbents

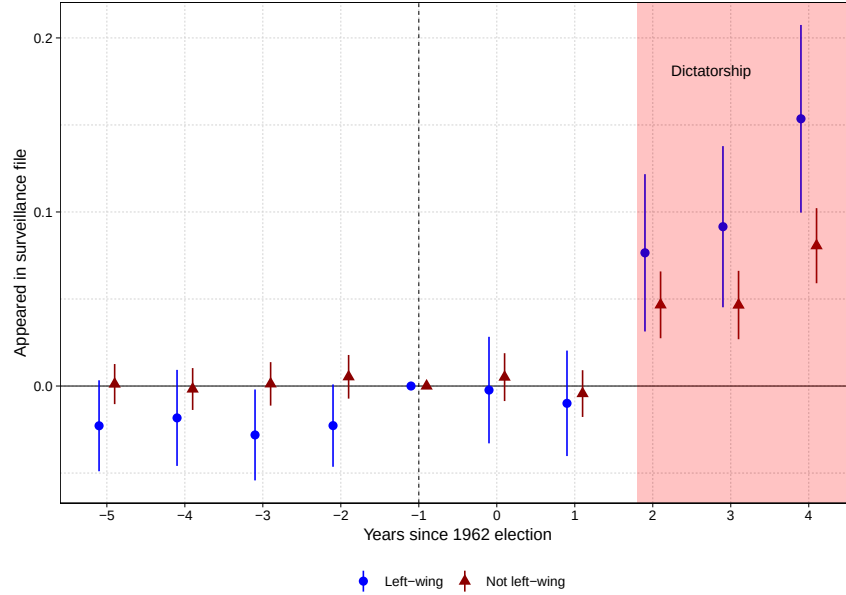


Figure 3: Surveillance of politicians, extensive margin.

were monitored most heavily, with left-wing politicians singled out in particular. It is worth noting that, although some pre-coup coefficients attain some level of statistical significance, their point estimates are small, and as a whole, there is no discernible pre-trend.

Table 1 summarizes these results in a standard differences-in-differences two-way fixed effect model. Although all coefficients are statistically significant, their magnitude varies considerably. The *Elected* $\times$ *After Coup* and *Left-wing* $\times$ *Elected* $\times$ *After Coup* coefficients are the most relevant of our test. The first indicates that 1962 incumbents attracted considerable attention from intelligence agencies after the coup. The second shows that this effect was markedly stronger for left-wing incumbents, who were monitored at roughly twice the rate of their non-left counterparts. Overall, these tests confirm that holding office during the coup, combined with a previous affiliation with left-wing parties, placed significant pressure on this group of politicians.

Table 1: Incumbency, Ideology, and Surveillance, Before and After the Coup

	N. of surveill. files (inverse sine)	Appeared in surveill. file
Elected $\times$ After Coup	0.057*** (0.012)	0.051*** (0.010)
Left-wing $\times$ Elected $\times$ After Coup	0.084** (0.037)	0.067** (0.028)
Left-wing	-0.002*** (0.001)	-0.001*** (0.000)
Elected	-0.006*** (0.001)	-0.005*** (0.001)
Left-wing $\times$ Elected	-0.008** (0.004)	-0.006** (0.003)
Left-wing $\times$ After Coup	0.019*** (0.006)	0.015*** (0.004)
Observations	216,233	216,233
R^2	0.254	0.206
Candidate FE	Yes	Yes
Year FE	Yes	Yes

Each observation is a 1962 candidate-year pair, starting in 1958 and continuing until 1966. Standard errors clustered by state in parentheses.

Significance levels: * $p < 0.1$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

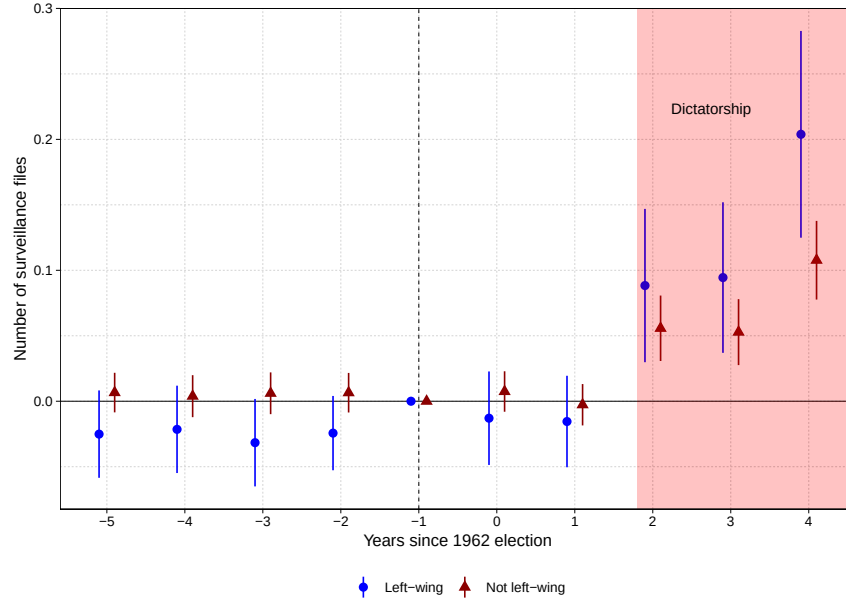


Figure 4: Surveillance of politicians, intensive margin.

Legacy Politicians and Political Selection

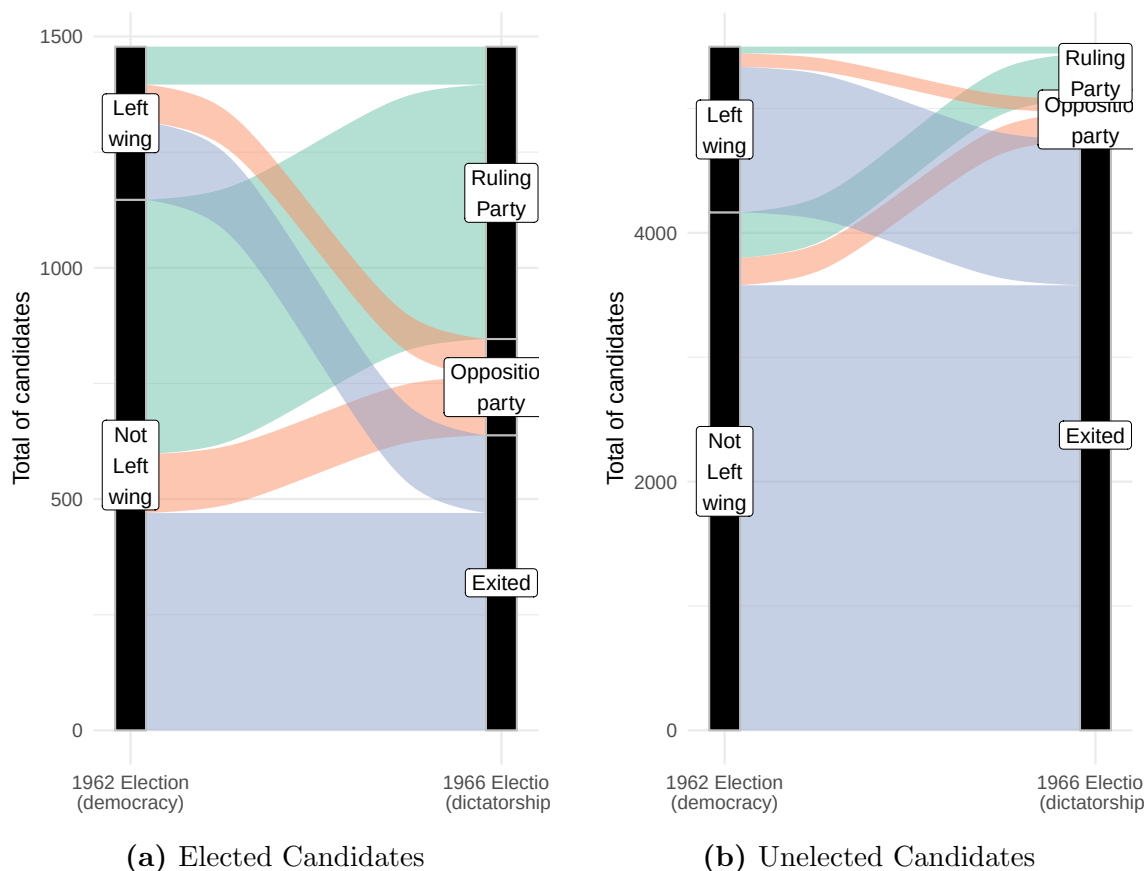
The military coup forced all legacy politicians to reevaluate their political careers. Figure 5 summarizes these trajectories for elected (left) and unelected (right) candidates. A majority decided to exit politics, especially among those who were not elected in 1962: 85% of 1962 losing candidates of any party did not run for Congressional office in 1966. Among incumbents, 40% chose to run again in 1966.¹² A majority of politicians who remained in politics sided with the ruling party, with a large proportion of those stemming from non-left-wing parties.¹³

As expected by our argument, left-wing politicians remained in politics at large rates, and many did so by joining the ruling party. Among elected left-wing politi-

¹²While the proportion of unelected candidates choosing to exit politics represented a 10 percentage point increase from the prior election in 1958, the proportion of exits among winning candidates remained virtually unchanged.

¹³The MDB was only able to gather enough members to compete in the 1966 election after the government Senate leadership induced three senators leaning towards the Arena to join the MDB (Nicolau, 2012; Kinzo, 1988; Fleischer, 1980).

Figure 5: Sankey diagrams for candidates who ran for office in 1962, examining their status for the 1966 election.

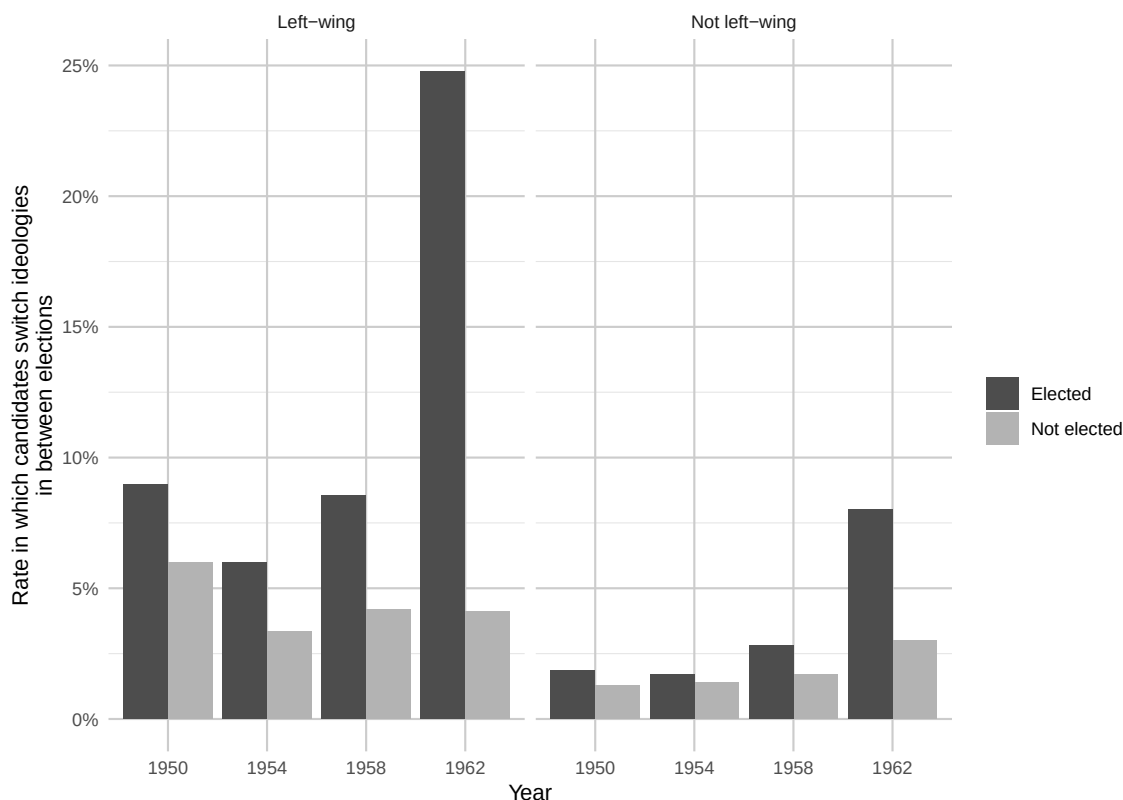


cians, 54% continued to pursue electoral careers under the dictatorship. Not only did this group remain in politics, but they were also very likely to do so within the ruling party—25% of elected left-wing politicians joined the ARENA.

The rate at which incumbent left-wing politicians switched sides was unparalleled. We create a measure that checks if a politician from the left (right) changes to the right (left) in a subsequent election to determine how common it was for politicians to completely let go of their ideological commitments. For this exercise, we consider the 1966 ruling party as right-wing and the opposition as left-wing. Figure 6 shows that not in the past, and not among any other group of politicians, has this rate of

change of ideology been seen before. Figure 15 in the Appendix demonstrates that the pattern of joining ARENA was consistent across candidates who were elected by narrow or large margins.¹⁴

Figure 6: Ideology switching during the democratic period and after the authoritarian reversal.



¹⁴When examining Arena membership across Brazilian regions, the rates are largely similar, with one notable exception: the South (see Section H in the Appendix). Rio Grande do Sul, in that region, is the case where our argument predicts the mechanism should break down. As the organizational heartland of the PTB and home state of both Vargas and Brizola, it is the context in which a switch to ARENA would have lacked credibility for both the regime and the politicians themselves.

Political Selection: Research Design and Estimation

In this subsection, we examine the career decisions of democratic political elites after the transition to dictatorship. The surveillance evidence establishes that incumbency was the primary dimension along which the regime sorted threats.¹⁵ The question is whether politicians internalized this asymmetric risk and responded accordingly. Descriptive patterns in Figure 5 are consistent with this claim, but elected and unelected politicians differ on many observable and unobservable dimensions that could independently shape their post-coup choices. Following the strong evidence presented in the analysis of surveillance, we claim that politicians who occupied an elected office during the regime transition are prominent. In turn, prominence draws attention and suspicion from the dictator.

We estimate the effects of becoming an incumbent in the last democratic election before the coup using a regression discontinuity (RD). RDs estimate local average treatment effects by assuming that while covariates and potential outcomes vary continuously over different values of a forcing variable that determines treatment assignment, the treatment assignment itself is discontinuous at a cutoff. When analyzing incumbency effects, this means that candidates who have barely won or barely lost an election are similar in observable and non-observable traits but different in the treatment condition (Lee and Lemieux, 2010; Dunning, 2012). Thus, the difference in outcomes between units close to the cutoff of treatment and control gives the local average treatment effect.

In our setting, the unit of analysis is the candidate; we observe the entire set of federal and state-level Congressional candidates who ran in the 1962 election. This includes a total of 7,113 candidates across elections, with 1,205 and 5,908 running for office at the federal and state level, respectively. A treated unit is the candidate who won a seat in the last congressional election before the regime change, and control units are candidates who lost.

To estimate the RD, each candidate running for office in 1962 received a score of how close they were to winning or losing the election – their margin of victory or

¹⁵And in other contexts as well. For example, see Esberg (2021).

defeat. In open-list proportional representation, the cutoff separating treatment and control units is a moving target that depends on the number of seats each electoral list receives after tallying the votes for all the candidates in the list. Once that is defined through the D'Hondt formula, candidates ranked equal to or above the number of seats allocated to the list receive a seat. The ranking of candidates within a list is solely decided by the number of votes received by the individual candidate. For example, if a list gets three seats, the third most-voted candidate is elected, while all other lower-ranked politicians do not receive a seat. That allows us to calculate the forcing variable of all candidates in that list. The distance, measured in vote shares, between this third candidate and a fourth non-elected candidate, is their respective score, with the difference that the elected candidate has a positive sign, and the non-elected candidate is in the control group and has a negative sign. In general terms, the margin of a winning candidate is their vote share minus the vote share of the best-ranked, non-elected candidate. The margin for losing candidates is their vote share minus the vote share of the worst-ranked, elected candidate.

For our baseline estimations, we opt for the local-linear regression model that captures the causal effect of incumbency

$$Y_{i,t+1} = \alpha + \beta_1 \textit{Elected}_{i,1962} + \beta_2 \textit{Margin}_{i,1962} + \beta_3 \textit{Elected}_{i,1962} * \textit{Margin}_{i,1962} + \mu_{i,1962} \\ \forall i.t. \quad |\textit{Margin}_i| < \epsilon \quad (2)$$

where $\textit{Elected}_{i_t}$ is a binary indicator equal to one if the candidate won the election in 1962, and β_1 measures its causal effect. $\textit{Margin}_{i,1962}$ is the margin for victory or defeat of candidate i , and $\mu_{i,1962}$ is an error term. ϵ is an arbitrarily small vote margin that defines the study group for each estimation. To estimate this model, we follow a non-parametric estimation procedure devised by Calonico, Cattaneo and Titiunik (2014).

In the Appendix, we provide evidence of the validity of the design. First, we test for bunching around the cutoff, which shows no signs that candidates self-select or are selected into the treatment group. Second, we show a balance test. The

historical data are meager in terms of pre-treatment covariates, complicating the test of balance. We circumvent this data limitation by operationalizing three covariates: the total number of last names, if the candidate has run in the previous 1958 election, or simply the number of times the candidate has run for office. In particular, it is not possible to use gender as a covariate since all candidates are men. The results of the balance tests provide credence to the design, as there is no perceptible effect on pre-treatment covariates.

Political Selection: Main Results

How did incumbency influence candidates' decisions regarding which dictatorship party to join or whether to exit politics altogether? Did incumbents use the two-party system to credibly signal their willingness to cooperate with the regime?¹⁶

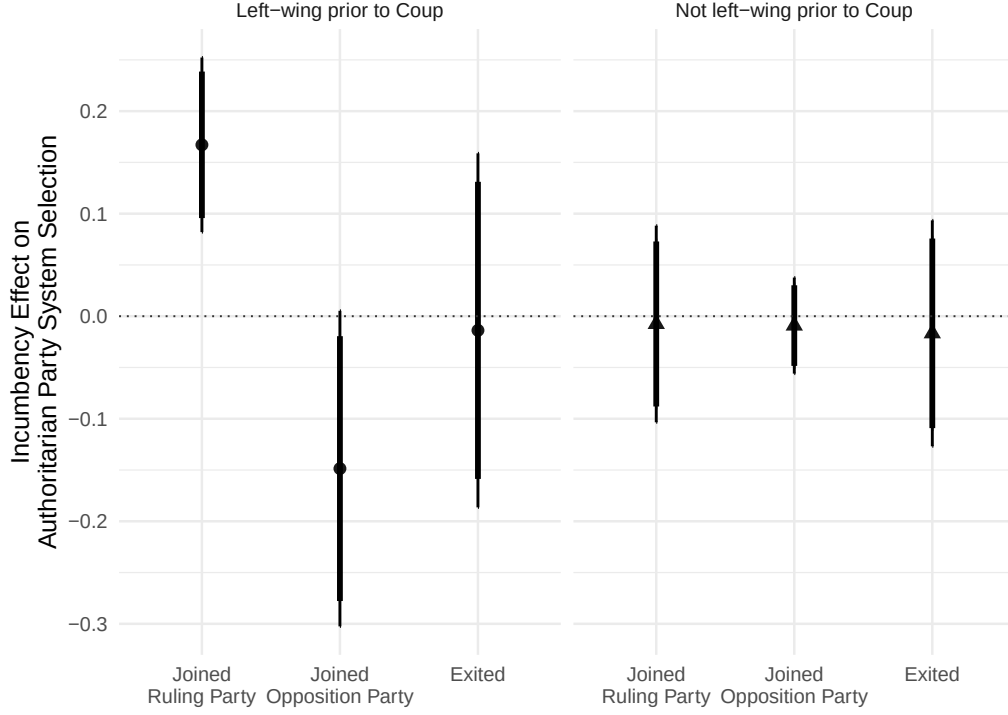
We first focus on left-wing politicians and analyze how incumbency at the time of the coup shaped three key post-transition outcomes: joining the ruling party (Arena), aligning with the opposition (MDB), or exiting politics entirely. The left panel in Figure 7 shows the results from our regression discontinuity analysis.

For left-wing incumbents, incumbency has a large positive effect on the probability of joining the regime. Specifically, left-wing incumbents are 20 percentage points more likely to join Arena than those who lost the pre-coup election. We also observe a negative effect of incumbency on the likelihood of joining the opposition party ($p < .06$), though there is no effect on the probability of exiting politics. These findings underscore the role of incumbency as a key factor in shaping strategies for political survival among politicians with prior ties to opposition social sectors.

Notably, these effects are specific to left-wing candidates. Our analysis shows that among non-left-wing politicians, incumbency does not significantly affect post-coup political decisions across any of the three outcomes (right panel in Figure 7). This

¹⁶In a first step, we show in Figure 11 that before the coup, elected politicians enjoyed an advantage over challengers in their next race. This result is evidence that incumbents were much more likely to retain power. From the dictator's perspective, we interpret this incumbency advantage as increased risk, since once they have access to power, politicians could better solidify their positions of influence. See Hidalgo and Oliveira (2016) for a more nuanced examination of incumbency effects for legislative offices in Brazil over time.

Figure 7: Incumbency and Political Selection: Regression Discontinuity Results



suggests that the political stakes and incentives tied to incumbency were particularly pronounced for left-wing elites, who may have faced greater pressure to signal loyalty to the regime to avoid the risk of retaliation or exclusion from power. Moreover, as Section I in the Appendix shows, the effects are even more pronounced among experienced politicians, who are not only more likely to have de facto power to counter the dictatorship but also more to lose, as they have established political careers.¹⁷

¹⁷We also present suggestive evidence that Arena members with backgrounds in left-wing parties acted consistently with their new partisan colleagues. Examining roll-call votes from the 1968 legislative session that culminated in a defeat for the military regime and precipitated the dictatorship's most repressive phase (the "Moreira Alves Affair"), we find that former left-wing politicians supported the government at rates comparable to other Arena members (Section E in the Appendix.)

By examining the divergent paths of left- and non-left-wing candidates, these results highlight the complex dynamics of political selection under authoritarian rule, where the decision of whether to join the regime and how to do so is shaped by politicians' needs to minimize the extent to which they are perceived as a threat to the regime. In the next section, we provide evidence of this mechanism by studying how incumbency shaped the extent to which politicians with ties to different civil society sectors were perceived as a threat by the regime.

Conclusion

Political elites who oppose authoritarian leaders play a crucial role in shaping regime consolidation and longevity. Yet even those excluded from the dictator's initial coalition often face strong incentives to join it. This paper argues that such capitulation, however, is not straightforward for all. Politicians who have prior connections to citizens and organized civil society are rightly perceived as a threat by the dictator, making them primary targets for repression.

Our central theoretical contribution explains how politicians can join the ruling authoritarian coalition while minimizing the risk of persecution. Electoral institutions, which a voluminous literature has shown help dictators credibly commit to distributing the spoils of office to the elites, also allow elites to commit to autocrats. By formally siding with the regime, elites decisively undermine their ability to mobilize societal actors, alleviating the dictator's concerns about popular opposition and easing their incorporation into the authoritarian coalition. Our empirical test, conducted in the context of Brazil's military dictatorship, supports our argument. Incumbent left-wing politicians were significantly more likely to be under the regime's surveillance and, at the same time, to join the ruling party.

This study contributes to the broader literature on authoritarian institutions by demonstrating how these institutions not only help autocrats consolidate power but also enable legacy elites to secure their own survival. It also sheds light on the micro-level mechanisms of authoritarian consolidation, revealing how individual-level career concerns can drive prominent opposition figures into cooperation with autocratic

regimes. Ultimately, our findings suggest that authoritarian electoral institutions serve a dual purpose: they allow dictators to co-opt elites while offering elites a viable path to political survival within repressive regimes.

An additional implication of our argument is that authoritarian electoral institutions might result in the loss of the political representation of opposition social sectors. When prominent opposition politicians defect to the ruling coalition, the organized sectors they once represented lose their institutional voice. By the time democracy returns, the political infrastructure of opposition may have atrophied, leaving authoritarian elites with a structural advantage in the post-transition order. Brazil's own transition, negotiated on terms largely favorable to the outgoing military and its civilian allies, fits this pattern. Future research might consider the implications of this claim for subsequent democratic transitions, especially the extent to which it might increase the relative advantage enjoyed by authoritarian elites during democratization processes led by themselves.

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A Summary table

	Avg	Median	Min	Max
Member Arena, 1966	0.15	0.00	0.00	1.00
Member MDB, 1966	0.08	0.00	0.00	1.00
Not a candidate, 1966	0.76	1.00	0.00	1.00
rights revoked, AI-1 (1964)	0.01	0.00	0.00	1.00
rights revoked, AI-5 (1968 -)	0.02	0.00	0.00	1.00
Number of votes	3501.65	1427.00	0.00	269384.00
Candidate, National Congress	0.17	0.00	0.00	1.00
Candidate, State Congress	0.83	1.00	0.00	1.00
Left-wing	0.24	0.00	0.00	1.00
Right-wing	0.48	0.00	0.00	1.00
Number of times candidate	0.67	0.00	0.00	8.00
Candidate in 1958	0.34	0.00	0.00	1.00

Table 2: 1962 Candidates

B Surveillance

Sources from Arquivo Nacional:

- Divisão de Segurança e Informações do Ministério da Justiça - BR RJANRIO TT
- Divisão de Segurança e Informações do Ministério das Relações Exteriores - BR RJANRIO Z4 / DFANBSB Z4
- Serviço Nacional de Informações - BR DFANBSB V8
- Conselho de Segurança Nacional - BR DFANBSB N8
- Centro de Informações de Segurança da Aeronáutica - BR DFANBSB VAZ
- Estado-Maior das Forças Armadas - BR RJANRIO 2M / BR DFANBSB 2M
- Departamento Administrativo do Serviço Público - BR DFANBSB 2C / BR RJANRIO 2C
- Comissão Geral de Inquérito Policial-Militar - BR DFANBSB AAJ
- Comissão Geral de Investigações - BR DFANBSB 1M / BR RJANRIO 1M

The documents obtained from the intelligence service (SNI) expose the extent and persistence of the regime's efforts to gather information on Brazilian civilians and politicians. Israel Dias Novaes, elected deputy in 1966 and purged in 1968, underwent rigorous scrutiny by the SNI. A dossier compiled years after his purge and successful return to Congress contains meticulous notes on his ideology, initial disapproval of the regime, and associations with known "subversives" (see Figure 8). In another file created by the regime's apparatus in Rio Grande do Sul in 1966, comprehensive information is provided on all MDB candidates running for state or federal Congress suspected of harboring sympathies for left-wing causes (see Figure

9).¹⁸ For instance, the file reveals that Antonio Bresolin, who was elected to the Federal Congress in 1966 as an MDB candidate, continued to secretly meet with members of his now-defunct party, the PTB (Figure 10).

The regime's surveillance was not limited to left-wing politicians. The intelligence network also served to produce information that could potentially threaten politicians with criminal charges for acts unrelated to the regime's ideological agenda. Documents on right-wing candidates demonstrate the regime's eagerness to uncover corrupt practices among them. Antonio Pereira de Almeida, elected to the state congress of Minas Gerais in 1962 as a member of the UDN and in 1966 through Arena, has a damaging intelligence file accusing him of vote-buying, fraud, and hiring hitmen to eliminate political rivals. This and numerous other examples show that while many files disclose individuals' connections to so-called "subversives," others report acts of misconduct.

¹⁸The file description states: *Backgrounds of candidates for state or federal deputy, highlighting that some are notably communists, signatories of various manifestos, and participants in numerous rallies in the state of Rio Grande do Sul.*

b. Atividades Atuais:

- 1) Deputado Federal pelo MDB/SP.
- 2) Jornalista
- 3) Pecuárísta em AVARÉ/SP

3. Juízo Sintético:

a. Posição Ideológica:

Esquerdistas. ISRAEL DIAS NOVAES não é um ativista com posição ideológica definida; seria melhor conceituado como um esquerdista pragmático, filosófico.

b. Ligações Políticas:

Com políticos do MDB, particularmente com ROBERTO CARDOSO ALVES.

c. Atitude em Face a Revolução de 31 Mar 64:

Contrário.

cont....

CONFIDENCIAL

Figure 8: SNI/SP file on Federal Deputy Israel Novaes (1979). (3a) notes the *ideological placement* of Novaes, (3b) notes the candidate's political network, and (3c) his disposition about the coup d'état.

03

DEPARTAMENTO DE ORDEN POLITICA E SOCIAL - DOPS

RELACAO DOS CANDIDATOS DO M.D.B. - (JERAL)

11.00
 CONTAS E
 REGISTROS
 D.O.P.S.
 Rio G. de Sol. Brasil

*ANTONIO FREZOLIN *	ERNESTO S. CORTESIAHIA - Nada Consta
*JOAO LINO REAIN - Nada Consta	*EDMUNDO MACHADO *
*MATHIAS JOSE SCHMIDT PIRIO *	*EDILIANO LUDERGER - Nada Consta
*OSCAR DA ROCHA GRAPULIA *	*FERNANDO ROLIA - Nada Consta
*RUBEN BERTO ALVES *	*FRANCISCO S. NETTO - Nada Consta
*RUBIO MACHADO *	*GERALDO DANIEL STEDILE
*ALCI PALMEIRO - Nada Consta	*JOAO JOAO DE MEDEIROS - Nada Consta
*AMADEU WEINANN *	*JOAO ALUISIO PIRIO *
*AMIR BUENO DORNELLES *	*JOAO FERREIRA NETO - Nada Consta
*ALDO AURY SCHLICHTING *	*LUIZITO TERNIGHONI - Nada Consta
*ALUIZIO PARAGUASSU FERREIRA	*LINO CARDO - Nada Consta
*DANIEL DIPP - Nada Consta	*MOISES VILASQUEZ - Nada Consta
*EDUARDO MARTINS ROLIN - Nada Consta	*MANAOS DRAGO GOULART - Nada Consta
*GERALDO LINDGREN - Nada Consta	*MANOEL ANDRE DA ROCHA *
*HARCKEL FONSELA LOPES	*MARCIONIRIO KOCK REIXEIRA - Nada Consta
*JOAO JOSE DE FREITAS LEAL - Nada Consta	*ROZAR BIANCHI DA ROCHA *
*MADIR ROBERTI - Nada Consta	*RENE HAMILTON ILHA *
*CEAVIO HIPOLITO *	*OSCAR WDA SILVEIRA - Nada Consta
*CAVIO CARLOS BROCHADO DA ROCHA - Nada Consta	*PEDRO GOMES DUNES *
*EDILSON GRILL *	*FELICIO DUARA - Nada Consta
*FLAVIO RAMOS	*FERRO A.T. DE GODOY - Nada Consta
*HOLI JOWER - Nada Consta	*RUBEN MACHADO LANS *
*AMARILIO B. MOREIRA *	*RAFAEL PERES BORGES *
*ALCIDES COSTA - Nada Consta	*RUBEN CLAIR VIANNA - Nada Consta
*ARISTIDES BERTUOL - Nada Consta	*RENATO SOUZA - Nada Consta
*ANSELMO AMARAL *	*SANTIAO GUEIRO *
*ANTENOR FERREIRA *	*SOLY GONZAGA DOS SANTOS *
*ANTONIO ROSA PIRES - Nada Consta	*SILVESTRE VARGAS - Nada Consta
*ARLANDO BARBOZA BRAGA	*VOLMI ALMEIDA REIS *
*CARLOS DA SILVA MARQUES	*ZAIIRA POLLI - Nada Consta
*CESO TESTA *	*VALDIR NOZZAQUANTRO - Nada Consta
*CASIANO PAEIDI DA NOZA - Nada Consta	*WALTON RICACHENECENT - Nada Consta
*CARLOS DO COUTO PRANCE - Nada Consta	*GERALDO MILLER BARLOS - Nada Consta
*ERICO LOURENÇO DE LIMA - Nada Consta	
*EMILIO WALTER BERGHANI - Nada Consta	

SUBLEGEMPA

*PAULO BROSGRAND DE SOUZA PIETO *
*MARIO DE ALMEIDA LIMA - Nada Consta
*HONORIO PEREIRA SEVERO - Nada Consta
*LUIZ AUGUSTO SOCHER DE AZAMBUJA *
*ARISTIDES MACEDO - Nada Consta
*NELSON RODENBUSH - Nada Consta
*IDENBURGO DE LIMA E SILVA - Nada Consta
*ADOLPHO FREGINA *

Figure 9: Intelligence file prepared for SNI headquarters categorizing MDB/RS 1966 candidates

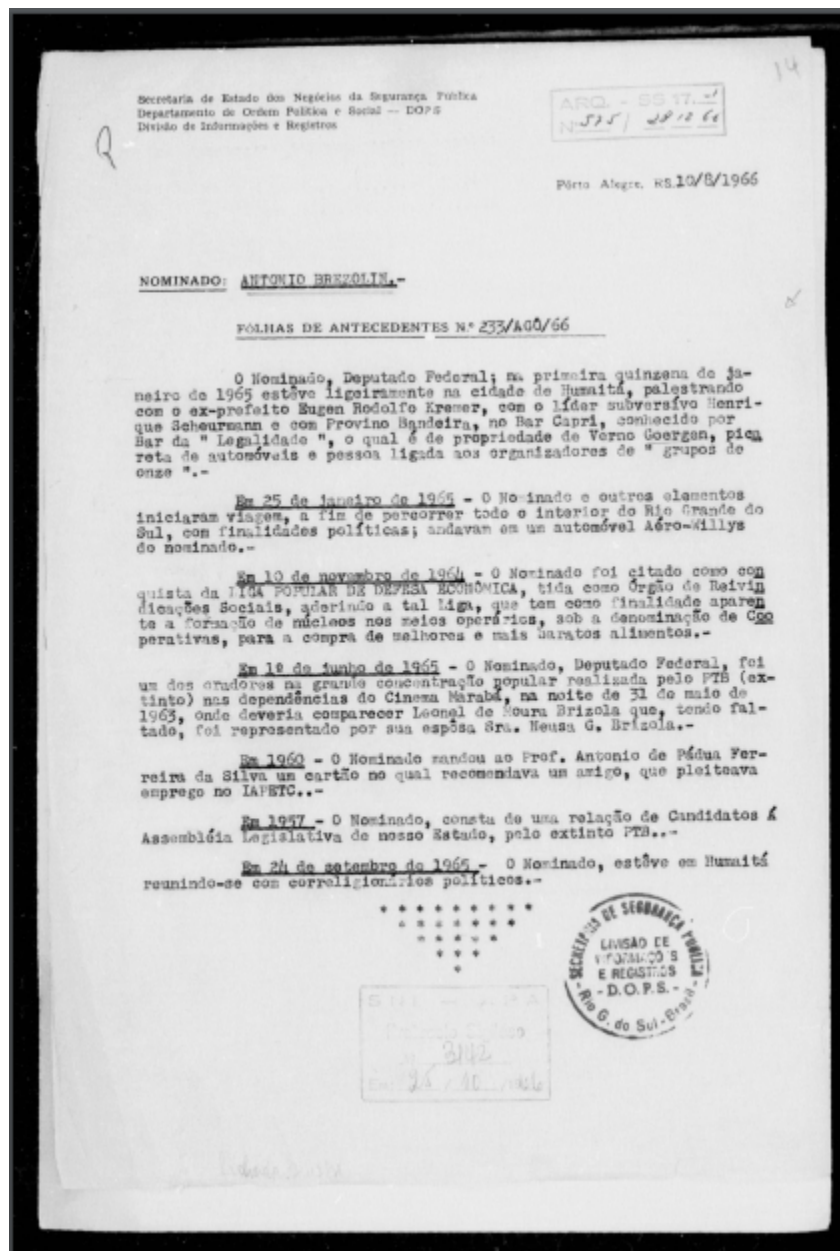


Figure 10: Antonio Brezolin's SNI file.

C Pre-coup outcomes

Table 3: Correlates of exiting politics, before the coup (1958 candidates)

	Exited
Left-wing	0.008 [0.016]
Elected	−0.347*** [0.020]
Left-wing x Elected	−0.020 [0.039]
Vote share	−1.268 [0.824]
Intercept	0.785* [0.342]
Num.Obs.	5593

+ $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Note:

OLS with state and office fixed effects, robust standard errors in brackets, p-values in parentheses.

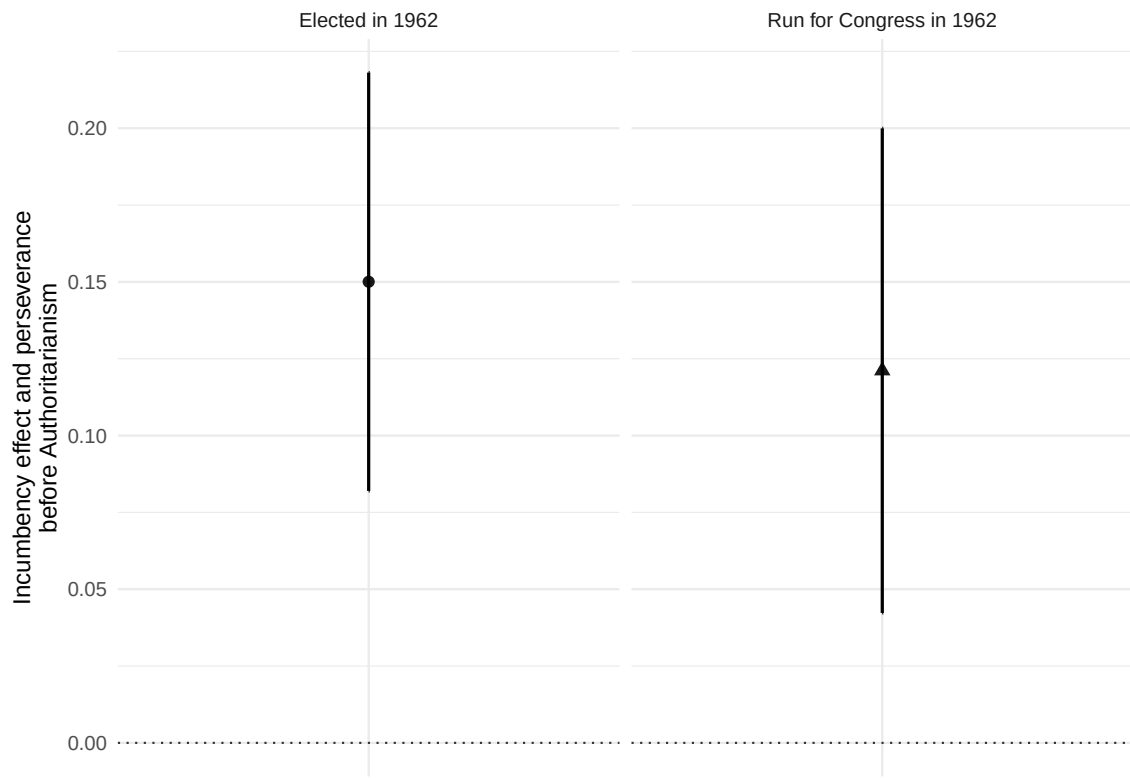


Figure 11: Incumbency and Political Selection before the Coup

Table 4: Correlates

	Joined Arena	Joined MDB	Exited
Left-wing	−0.040*** [0.007]	0.028*** [0.008]	0.009 [0.011]
Elected	0.370*** [0.017]	0.046*** [0.011]	−0.416*** [0.017]
Left-wing x Elected	−0.180*** [0.029]	0.105*** [0.027]	0.025 [0.033]
Vote share	0.343 [0.518]	0.658 [0.445]	−1.961*** [0.560]
Intercept	0.140* [0.057]	0.115* [0.047]	0.795*** [0.063]
Num.Obs.	6971	6971	6971

+ $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Note:

OLS with state and office fixed effects, robust standard errors in brackets, p-values in parentheses.

D RDD validity tests

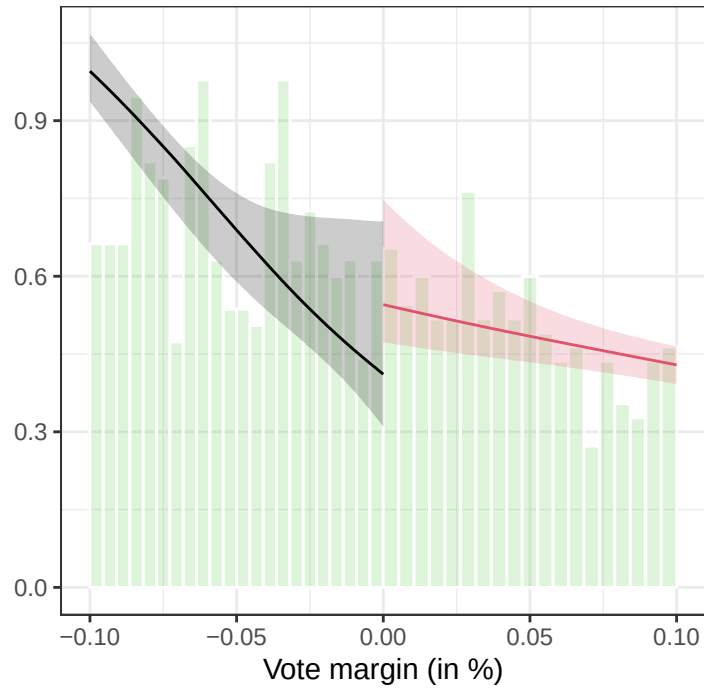


Figure 12: Density test. *Nonparametric density test around the RDD cutoff, following Cattaneo, Jansson and Ma (2017)*

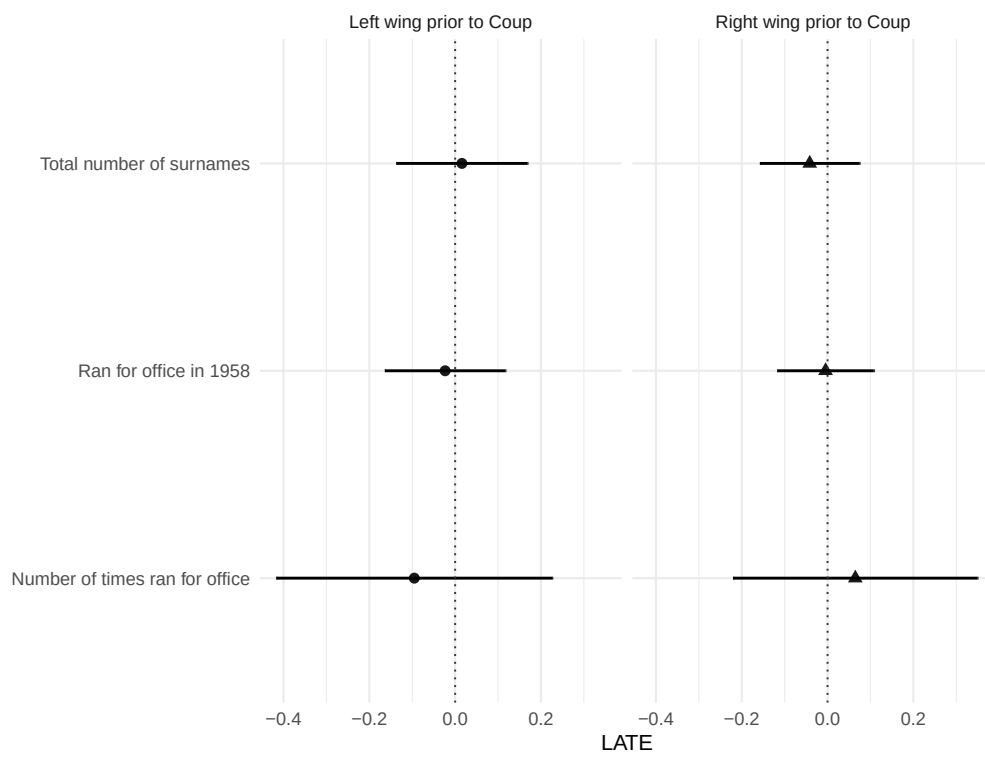


Figure 13: Balance tests.

E The Moreira Alves vote case

The military hardliners decided to ramp up repression in 1968 after Congress showed that it was not completely submissive. In September of that year, MDB federal deputy from Rio de Janeiro state, Marcio Moreira Alves, delivered a speech on the Congress floor critical of the military. At first, the military demanded Congress to formally sanction Alves, opening proceedings to decide if he should face a vote to be removed from office. However, a majority, including many Arena politicians, decided against moving forward. The hardliners seized the opportunity to pass the AI-5 (Skidmore, 1989) and rapidly moved on to purge those who had been critical of the military, taking special interest in those who prevented the dismissal of Moreira Alves (Grinberg, 2022).

Meticulous record-keeping shows that one intelligence branch of the military went on a case-by-case analysis of the secret vote by Arena members, noting who was for the motion, who was against it, whose disposition was unclear, and who was absent during the vote.¹⁹ No archived document shows the same diligence in recording how MDB politicians voted.

We use this historical record of how the military perceived the vote to check if the military viewed past left-wing deputies in the Arena as more suspicious and, indirectly if those candidates were more likely to go against the regime’s interests. It is possible that their formal membership to the regime party was nothing other than cheap talk. Individual dossiers prepared to discuss and decide purges in a committee formed by cabinet members, top military and President Costa e Silva often mention that former PTB candidates in the Arena joined the party opportunistically and that they had never let go of their left-wing tendencies.

Instead, the evidence suggests that left-wing deputies within the Arena were no more likely to vote against the dictatorship than those previously affiliated to other parties (Figure 15).

¹⁹Archive file “BR DFANBSB N8.0.PSN” from the *Conselho Nacional de Segurança*, available at the *Arquivo Nacional* website.

PRESIDÊNCIA DA REPÚBLICA		
SECRETO		
PERNAMBUCO	Aderbal Jurema.....	A favor
	Arruda Câmara.....	Contra licença
	Aurino Valois.....	A favor
	Carlos Alberto Oliveira.....	Contra licença
	Cid Sampaio.....	Contra licença
	Dias Lins.....	Não compareceu
	Geraldo Cuedes.....	Contra licença
	João Roma.....	Contra licença
	José Carlos Guerra.....	Contra licença
	José Meira.....	Não compareceu
	Josias Leite.....	Contra licença
	Magalhães Mello.....	A favor
	Milvernes Lima.....	A favor
	Mouri Fernandes.....	Contra licença
	Paulo Maciel.....	Contra licença
	Souto Maior.....	A favor
ALAGOAS	Tabosa de Almeida.....	Contra licença
	Alde Sampaio.....	Contra licença
	Bezerra Leite.....	A favor (?)
	Aloysio Moniz.....	Não compareceu
	Luiz Cavalcante.....	A favor
	Medeiros Neto.....	A favor
	Oceano Carleial.....	Contra licença
	Oséas Cardoso.....	A favor
	Pereira Lácio.....	Contra licença
	Segismundo Andrade.....	Contra licença
Arnaldo Carneiro.....		A favor

Figure 14: Intelligence file containing information on Arena votes for and against the motion to place Marcio Moreira Alves on leave. “A favor” votes are in favor of placing him on leave, and “Contra Licença” votes are against it. Other markings note abstentions or uncertainty.

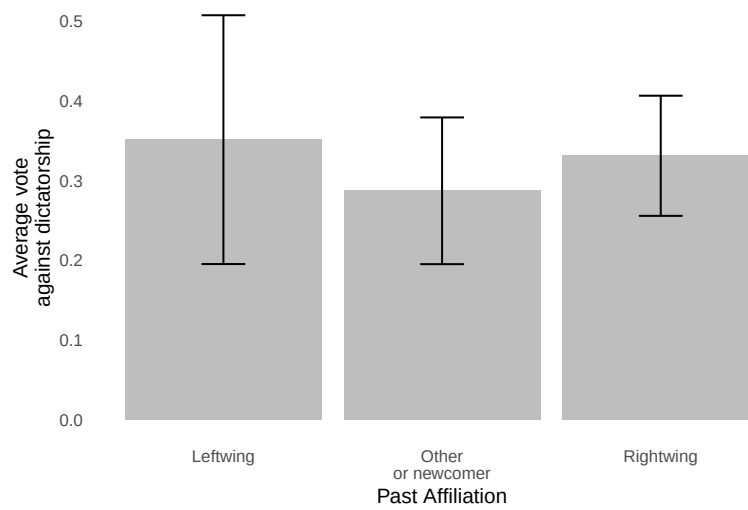
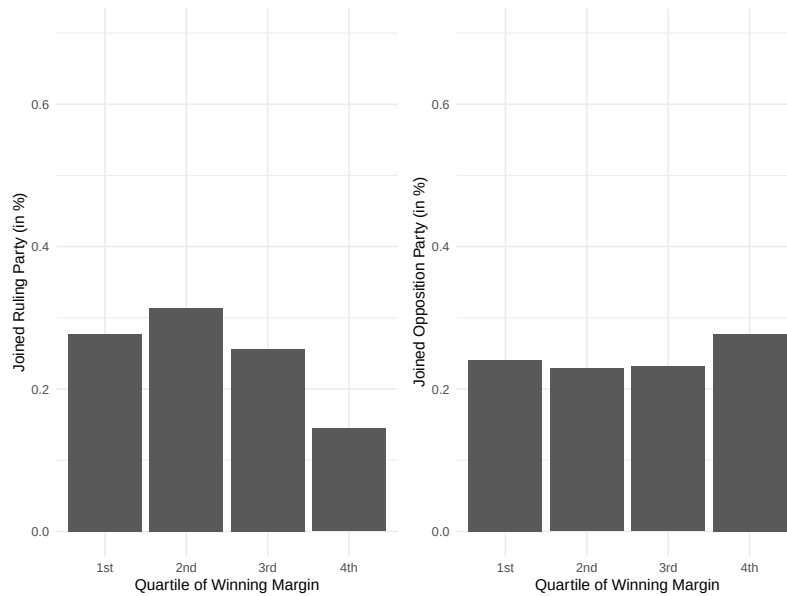


Figure 15: Arena votes against dictatorship interest in 1968, according to dictatorship intelligence. *Error bars represent 95% confidence intervals.*

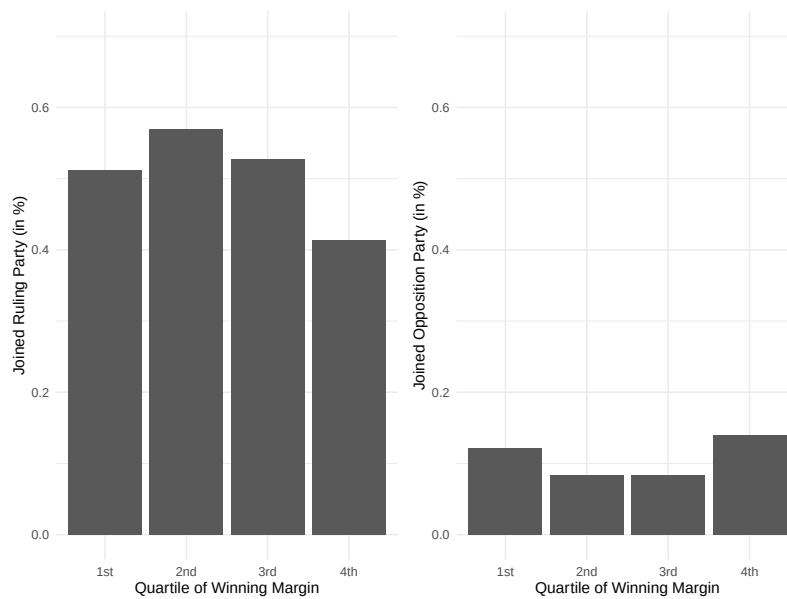
F Margin of Victory and Political Selection

There is no relationship between the choice of party they join and the margin of victory among elected politicians. In Figures 15 and ?? we divide winning candidates into quartiles of winning margins. It is clear that elected right-wing politicians joined the regime party more than the opposition party at similar rates for any quartile, while among left-wing politicians the choice of Arena or MDB seems balanced. Yet, although candidates with the widest margin appear to prefer joining the MDB, candidates in other quartiles preferred joining the Arena in a consistent way. This pattern is indicative that RDD results in the following section showing an incumbency effect among left-wing candidates who have barely won the election joining the Arena cannot be solely explained by the electoral vulnerability of these candidates.

Figure 16: Political selection of elected legacy politicians in authoritarian Brazil by margin of victory



(a) Politicians formerly affiliated with the left



(b) Politicians formerly affiliated with non left-wing parties

G Arena membership and political appointments

We posit that politicians who side with authoritarian regimes enjoy better career prospects, including appointments outside electoral politics. To attest whether that took place in authoritarian Brazil, we assembled a novel dataset using information from the historical and biographical archive of the Center for Research and Documentation of Contemporary History of Brazil, from the Getulio Vargas Foundation, to reconstruct the career path of notable 1962 politicians.²⁰ The biographical entries in the archive provide consistent information on education, previous occupations, and public appointments these politicians accepted after the coup in 1964. These high-visibility posts are a subset of the potential benefits well-connected politicians accrue even when not winning elections.

In total, we gathered information from 265 legacy politicians who persevered after the coup and 257 of whom had run for federal deputy. One case is Aurino Valois, elected to Congress in 1962 as a member of PTB/Pernambuco. After the coup, he joined the Arena, and after his electoral luck ran out in 1970, he was eventually appointed as a director of the state-owned mining giant Vale do Rio Doce in 1975.²¹ In total, we identify 111 politicians who have received appointments, ranging from SOEs board memberships, federal and state-level cabinet positions, and state agencies.

Estimations show that Arena membership correlates with more political appointments. Column 1 in Table ?? show that, overall, 1962 politicians that flocked to Arena received more political appointments during the dictatorship. The pattern is driven by former left-wing candidates. In column 2, the coefficient for Left-wing candidates shows that these types of candidates are less likely to be appointed, but for those left-wing politicians that end up joining Arena, represented by the interaction term, not only the penalty of having been a member of left-wing coalitions vanish, but they are rewarded. These results are in line with our argument, as they suggest that joining the dictatorship side increases the odds of receiving political

²⁰<https://cpdoc.fgv.br/acervo/dicionarios>

²¹<https://www18.fgv.br/cpdoc/acervo/dicionarios/verbete-biografico/aurino-do-nascimento-valois>, accessed on 02-09-2024.

Table 5: Arena membership and political appointments

	[1]	[2]	[3]
Arena	0.118* (0.052)	0.042 (0.065)	0.235+ (0.136)
Left-wing		-0.156* (0.077)	
Arena * Left-wing		0.223+ (0.129)	
Constant	0.376 (0.303)	0.482 (0.315)	0.273 (0.487)
Num.Obs.	265	265	75
R2	0.088	0.105	0.303

+ $p < 0.1$, * $p < 0.05$, ** $p < 0.01$, *** $p < 0.001$

Note:

Observations include legacy deputies who continued their careers after the coup and appear on the CP-DOC website. All estimations include state and office fixed effects, and controls for incumbency status, union membership and landownership, the last two variables extracted from CPDOC. Robust standard errors in parentheses. Column 3 only includes candidates running in left-wing coalitions in 1962.

rents.

H The Costs of Joining the Regime

When examining Arena membership across Brazilian regions, rates are not strikingly different, with one clear outlier: the South. That low rate can be traced back to the state of Rio Grande do Sul, the home of Getúlio Vargas, Leonel Brizola, and the PTB. In that state, out of 22 elected candidates, not even one joined the Arena. Although understanding what happened there demands a careful qualitative analysis that is beyond the scope of this paper, it illustrates that there is a cost in backing away from a party and its ties to society. When the cost is too large, politicians might refrain from openly siding with an authoritarian regime.

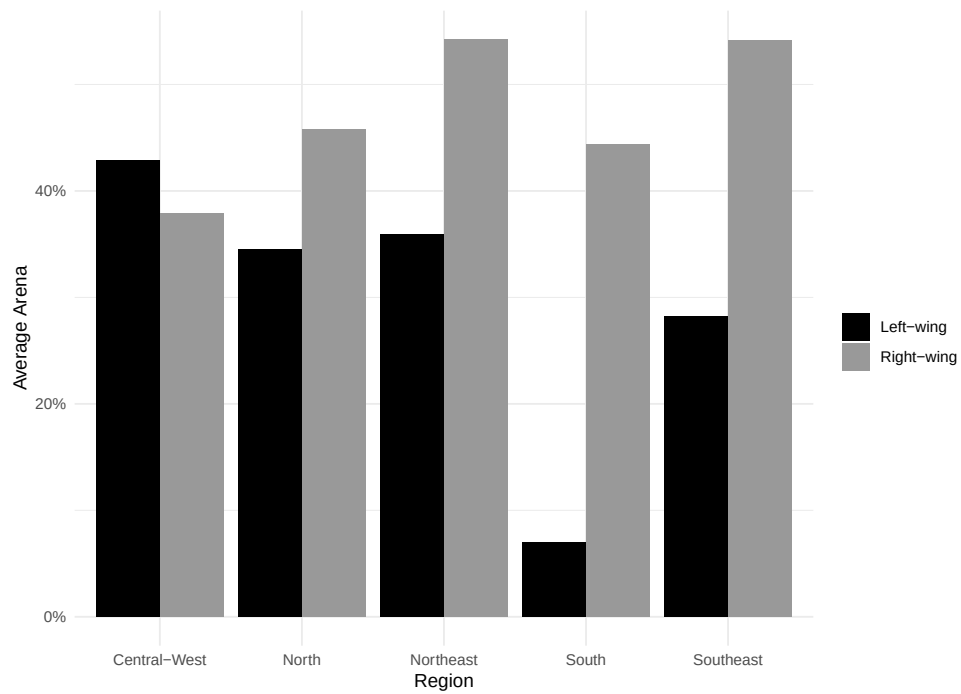
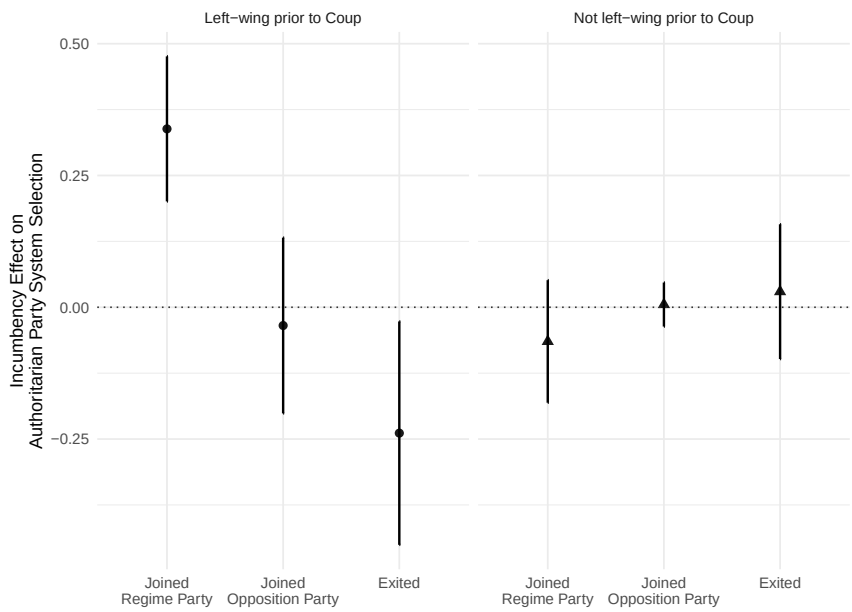


Figure 17: Average Arena Membership of Elected Legacy Politicians, by Region and 1962 Party Ideology

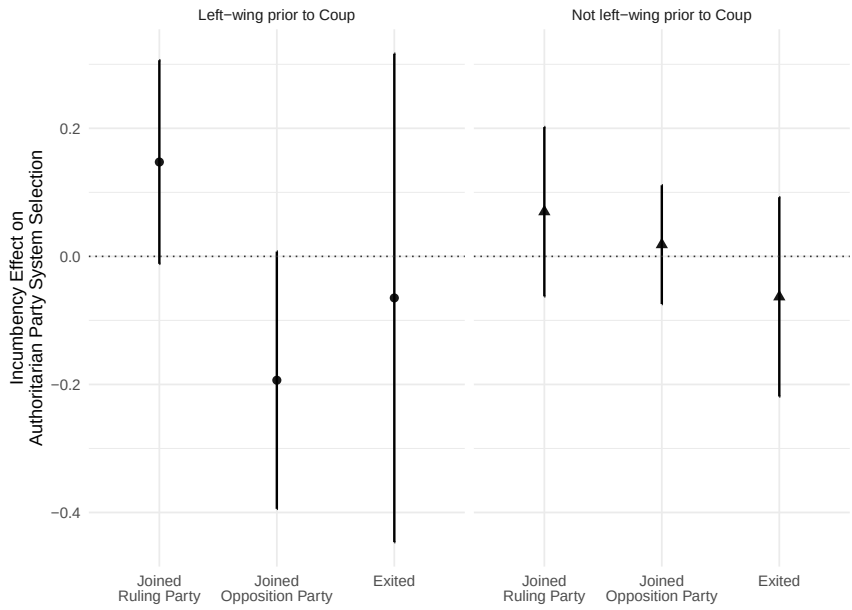
I Experience and ARENA membership

The effects among more experienced left-wing candidates are even larger. Considering that these are the candidates that have a greater sunk investment in politics, from the standpoint of careerism, these are the politicians more likely to side with the regime. But these are also the politicians with greater resources and connections, potentially more powerful. Yet, prominence clearly shows that they are eager to join the regime party, as Figure 18a shows. We also observe a negative effect on exiting politics. In Figure 18b we show the results for inexperienced candidates who ran for the first time in 1962. Although incumbency appears to affect their choice of joining the regime, too, the size of the point estimate is just half of the one measured for experienced peers. In contrast, estimations among right-wing politicians are consistent across different levels of experience.

Figure 18: Heterogeneous Treatment Effects by Experience



(a) Experienced Politicians



(b) Inexperienced Politicians